





Tuning in to Cop Music

With covers ranging from Rafi hits to the 007 theme, ***Khaki Studio****, the Mumbai Police band, goes viral*

Sanjay Kalyani bows towards the camera, then spins around and gesticulates. The merry band of musicians in front of him takes off. Shots of Daniel Craig in a high-speed car chase are spliced through this two-minute music video, as the 86-year-old Mumbai Police band renders the James Bond theme in all its instrumental glory. Clad in khaki, bandmaster Kalyani, 42, emphatically guides the band to a crescendo. With more than 62,000 YouTube views, Khaki Studio, the Mumbai Police band, has been delivering one viral hit after another; from anti-fascist Italian folk song 'Bella Ciao' to Kishore Kumar's 'Mere Sapnon Ki Rani'.

"My favourite song?" Kalyani laughs at the question. "Every note of music gives me a good feeling. They are all my favourites." The same can be said for his audience, too. The band's latest cover of Mohammed Rafi's 1967 classic 'An Evening in Paris' is also its latest online hit. "Through music, we hope to strengthen the police's relationship with the public," says Kalyani, who previously worked in an Indian navy band. "We want to win the hearts of people."



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The 102 instrumentalists led by Kalyani are recruited through a separate quota. They practise daily for a few hours. The band features flautists, clarinet players, saxophonists and percussionists. They play at ceremonial events, at the Raj Bhavan, during special parades, at competitions and often at outdoor locations for the public. They are often also booked for private events. And while they are solely devoted to their music, occasionally they are also roped in for *bandobast* duty, or when there is a shortfall in police personnel.

Police historian Rohidas Dusar says the band was formed in curious circumstances. At King George V's silver jubilee function in 1935, a police parade was to take place at the headquarters in central Bombay and the authorities invited the military band to play, as was the custom. "Everyone said it was a great function, but some said this is a police function and the band is not theirs," says Dusar. Prominent citizens then pooled in to buy instruments and put together a police band. For seven months, this group practised, and then joined the ceremonial welcome for new Viceroy Linlithgow when he docked at the Gateway of India on April 17, 1936. Later, at a police function on December 18, the band officially debuted as the Bombay police band.

Eighty-six years on, they are no longer limited to formal performances. They even take song requests online. "We are thrilled to reach so many people through social media as well," says Sudhir Beluse, 57, an assistant bandmaster and trumpeter who joined as a band boy at the age of 14. "You get to perform at big functions, travel, learn and show your talent." ■

–Bhavya Dore